

Windows 10 ISO, the procedure to move roll back to the previous Windows version can be different.

If you installed via Windows update or run the upgrade process from an ISO of Windows 10, there is an inbuilt process for rolling back to your previous version of Windows that should be the method of choice.

In some cases, this rollback is not available. If you upgraded from Windows 8 (not 8.1) to Windows 10 using the ISO. Or if you upgraded from XP / Windows Vista using the ISO. Or if you used the ISO to do a clean install. In all these cases you need to back up your important data!

While downgrading Windows these days is mostly a safe operation, as Windows tries to retain as much of your old data as it can, don't take it for granted. Backing up the data is a vital part of the process of downgrading from any Windows version.

Versions of Windows since Windows Vista take the approach of retaining all your old data even if you do a clean reinstall (without formatting of course). It places all your old files in a folder called 'Windows.old'.

Now, don't be misled by the name 'Windows.old', it doesn't refer to the version of Windows. If you have Windows 10 installed and then install Windows 7 on that same drive, the contents of 'Windows.old' will be your Windows 10 install.

You can go inside this 'Windows.old' folder and copy back any important data you have, such as documents, photos, and videos. Even some application settings might be recoverable.

In case you are reverting back to Windows XP, the downgrade process is as good as a format and reinstall; back up everything!

In fact, just back up everything; that is never the wrong advice to give. If you keep data in odd places on your Windows partition, back those up, a Windows reinstall might not be kind to them.

Backup your Windows 10 data

Remember, backups only count if they are on a separate drive or at least partition. Make sure that you create a backup of your data on the external hard drive, USB, or cloud services such as DropBox, Google Drive, Microsoft OneDrive, etc.

The most important thing to know is where your data is stored in the layout Windows uses. In the following examples we assume you installed Windows in C: drive, if not replace 'C:' with whatever drive letter Windows is using for your install.